

Chapter 9: Indian Ocean Exchange

Unit 2 • Ch. 9 • c. 1200–1450
AP World History: Modern

CUE COLUMN (cover & recall)

NOTES COLUMN (main content)

Indian Ocean Trade Network

- World's most active pre-modern maritime system, c. 1200–1450
- Connected: East Africa → Arabian Peninsula → Persia → India → SE Asia → China
 - Driven by MONSOON WINDS (seasonal, predictable, reversible) not political stability
 - More resilient than Silk Roads — survived collapse of Abbasid Caliphate & Mongol invasion
 - Multi-religious: Muslim, Hindu, Buddhist, and later Christian merchants coexisted

Monsoon Winds & the Dhow

- Monsoon winds:** summer = SW winds (push ships NE toward India/SE Asia); winter = NE winds (push SW toward Arabia/Africa)
- Predictable calendar meant sailors planned voyages around monsoon seasons
 - Natural infrastructure = more resilient than overland political stability
- Dhow:** Arab sailing vessel with lateen (triangular) sail — can sail at angles to wind
- Lateen sail = ships could navigate monsoon patterns in both directions

Swahili Coast (East Africa)

- Series of prosperous city-states: Kilwa, Mombasa, Zanzibar, Malindi, Sofala
- Exported: African gold (from Great Zimbabwe), ivory, enslaved people
 - Imported: Indian textiles, Chinese porcelain, Islamic luxury goods
 - Culture: Bantu African + Arabic + Islamic hybrid — stone mosque architecture
- Kilwa:** Ibn Battuta visited 1331; described as one of the world's finest cities
- Chinese porcelain found archaeologically = evidence of Indian Ocean network reach

Malacca & SE Asian Trade

- Malacca Sultanate (c. 1400):** founded at chokepoint of Strait of Malacca
- Ruler converted to Islam c. 1400 → attracted Muslim merchant network
 - Model: voluntary conversion for commercial + diplomatic advantage (not forced)
 - Whoever controlled the Strait taxed ALL traffic between Indian Ocean and South China Sea
 - Islam spread across SE Asia through this commercial-religious mechanism

Zheng He's Voyages 1405–1433

- 7 voyages** commissioned by Ming Emperor Yongle; commanded by Muslim admiral Zheng He
- Fleet: hundreds of ships incl. 'treasure ships' ~9x size of Columbus's Santa María
 - Reached: SE Asia, India, Persian Gulf, East Africa (brought back giraffes to China)
 - Purpose: DIPLOMATIC (collect tribute, assert Ming prestige) — NOT commercial
 - Discontinued after Yongle died: Confucian court reversed policy; fleet records burned
- AP EXAM: Zheng He withdrawal = state policy determines trade participation; creates vacuum Europeans fill

Islam's Spread via Indian Ocean

- Primary mechanism: Muslim merchants established diasporic communities in every port
- Commercial advantage → local rulers converted to Islam for trade access
 - No military conquest required — voluntary conversion driven by commercial incentives
- East Africa:** Swahili city-state rulers converted; Islamic architecture built
- South Asia:** Malabar Coast, Gujarat Muslim communities; later Delhi Sultanate
- SE Asia:** Malacca's conversion model replicated across Malay Archipelago

Indian Ocean vs. Silk Roads (comparison)

- Indian Ocean:** driven by monsoon winds; decentralized; no single empire controls it; more resilient
- Silk Roads:** overland; dependent on political stability (Pax Mongolica); declined with Mongol collapse
- Indian Ocean survived: Abbasid collapse, Mongol invasion, Black Death → continued throughout
- Silk Roads REQUIRED unified political control → fragmented when Mongols collapsed
- ↔ **This comparison appears almost every AP exam year — know it cold**

AP Exam Tips
Ch. 9

★ **HIGH-YIELD:** Indian Ocean trade is tested through artifacts (porcelain, mosque architecture), traveler accounts

- **TRAP:** Don't say Indian Ocean trade 'ended' when Mongols fell — it didn't depend on Mongol rule
- **TRAP:** Zheng He's voyages were **DIPLOMATIC** (tribute), not commercial like private merchants
- **TRAP:** Islam spread through Indian Ocean via **MERCHANTS**, not military conquest
- ✓ **KEY:** Portuguese entry **1498** disrupts Muslim dominance — **Unit 3 hinge point**

SUMMARY — Write a 3-5 sentence synthesis in your own words:

The Indian Ocean trade network was the world's most active pre-modern maritime system, powered by predictable monsoon winds and sustained by Muslim merchant diasporas rather than any single political empire. Unlike the Silk Roads, which required Mongol political stability, the Indian Ocean network was resilient — it survived the collapse of the Abbasid Caliphate and the Mongol invasions. Swahili city-states on East Africa's coast (especially Kilwa) prospered by connecting African gold to Indian Ocean commerce. The Malaccan Sultanate (c. 1400) became the dominant Southeast Asian hub when its ruler converted to Islam for commercial advantage, spreading Islam throughout the region. The Ming Dynasty's Zheng He voyages (1405–1433) demonstrated Chinese naval capability but were discontinued by the Confucian court — creating the power vacuum that Portuguese explorers would fill after 1498.

My summary in my own words:
